

1987

INDIA AT 60

BATTLE OF DOOM

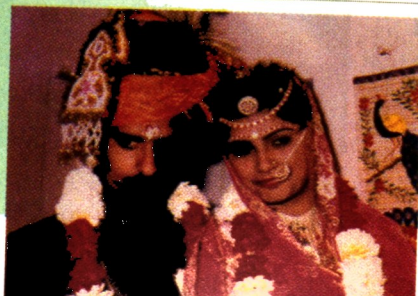
◀◀ REWIND



In a year that had seen Rajiv Gandhi swamped with one crisis after another, from the resignation of foreign secretary A. P. Venkateswaran to the bitter relationship with President Giani Zail Singh, the Bofors controversy left a gaping hole in his credibility. A year after the Rs 1,705-crore Bofors deal had been inked, it became the proverbial loaded gun, as allegations of irregularities in the purchase broke out on Swedish Radio. Almost as damaging as the allegations themselves was the Government's bungling of the affair. And then, as if these weren't enough, Rajiv sent to Sri Lanka the Indian Peacekeeping Force to rein in its brainchild, the LTTE, as the civil war in the embattled island spiralled out of control. The army got bogged down in what was to be a swift, clinical action by an unfamiliarity with the terrain, civilian hostility and orders to avoid civilian casualties, and thus began India's most disastrous overseas military expedition.

FIRST CUT

On September 4, Roop Kanwar seemingly set herself afire on her husband's funeral pyre at Deorala in Rajasthan, bringing to light the practice of sati.



◀◀ DID YOU KNOW

In what threatened to be a sequel to the controversial Shah Bano case of 1985, another Muslim woman, Saira Banu, was also awarded a maintenance from her divorced husband.